



MASSEY UNIVERSITY

Human development: Pacific Perspectives

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Overview

Goal(s):

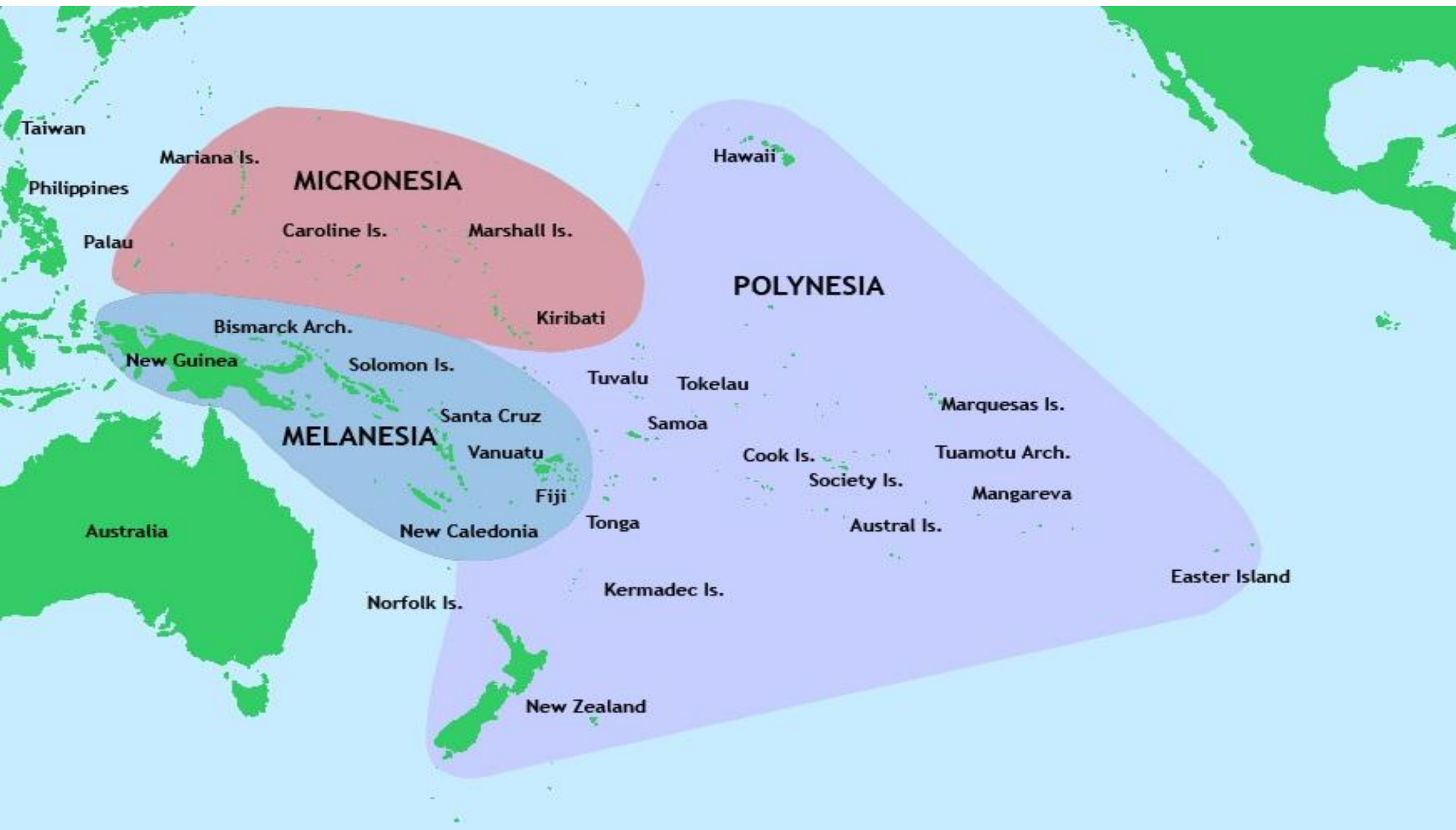
- To introduce you to the Pasifika context in Aotearoa NZ
- To discuss some core Pasifika values
- To discuss some current educational aspirations and challenges for Pasifika peoples in Aotearoa NZ

Who are Pasifika peoples?

- “Pacific Islanders” - a term previously used.
- More recently terms used is “Pasifika peoples”. “Pacific” translates into “Pasifika” in several different Pacific languages. More importantly the term itself has come from Pasifika peoples as a way to define themselves

Who are Pasifika peoples?

Multi-ethnic group within Aotearoa/New Zealand. Pasifika peoples are a heterogeneous group from a range of Pacific Island nations and including those born in New Zealand who identify themselves with the Pacific Islands and those who have migrated from the Pacific Islands (Coxon, Anae, Mara, Wendt-Samu & Finau, 2002).



Who are Pasifika peoples?

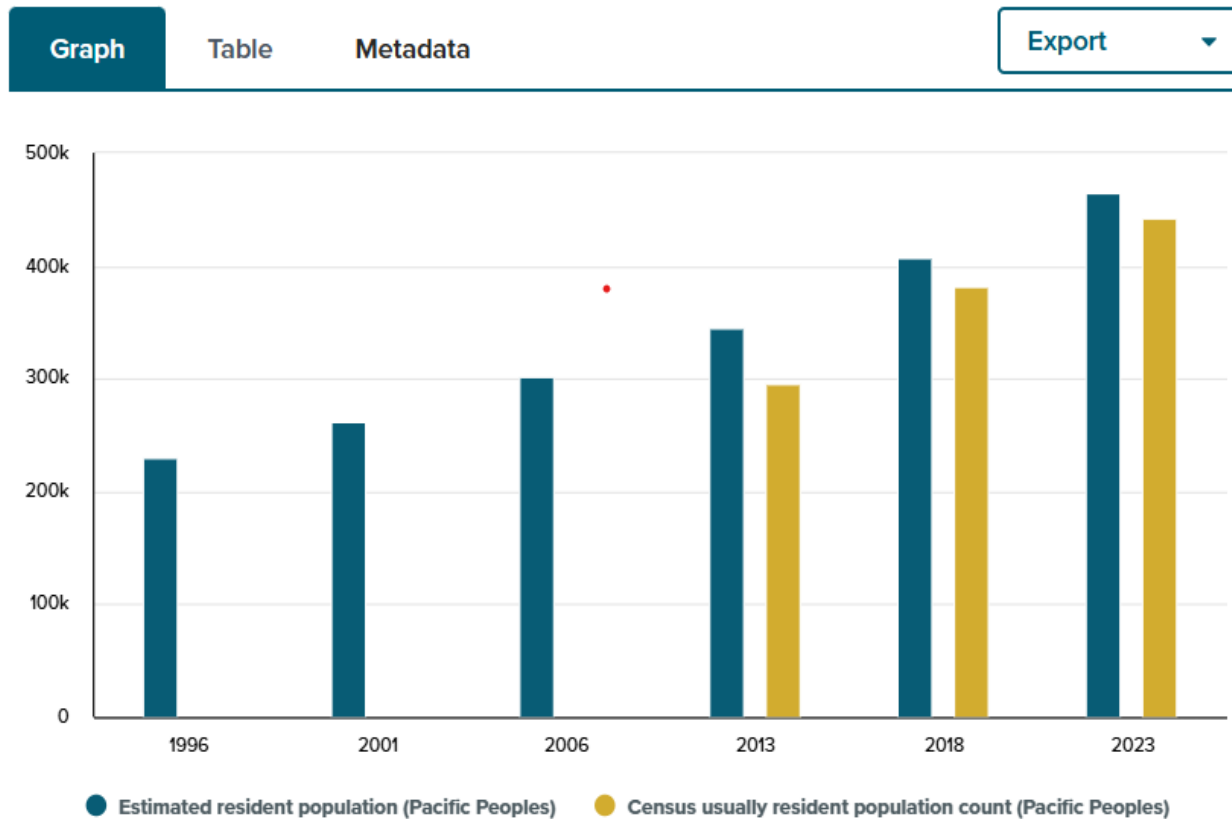
- Different countries with similar but different languages, cultural concepts, traditions, and history.
- (approx.) 65% of those who identify themselves as of Pacific descent are New Zealand born and second or third generation. This is important to remember, because the majority of current Pasifika peoples in Aotearoa are not people who grew up in the islands (context/environment matters when considering perspectives, development etc)

Pasifika migration to Aotearoa NZ

- A small number of people began migrating to NZ when some Pacific Island Governments sent students here to study on scholarships. Most of the students returned after they completed their study but a few stayed and chose New Zealand to be their home.
- The major influx of Pacific Islanders happened when there was a shortage of manual labour as a result of a boom in the New Zealand economy. NZ government of the time provided a solution; it negotiated a deal with some Pacific Island Governments to send labourers here on work contracts and with the possibility of staying on in NZ. So lots of Pasifika people were brought in to cover the shortage, and at the end of their contract many Pasifika peoples chose to stay on in New Zealand.

Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

Population of the Pacific Peoples ethnic group, 1996–2023



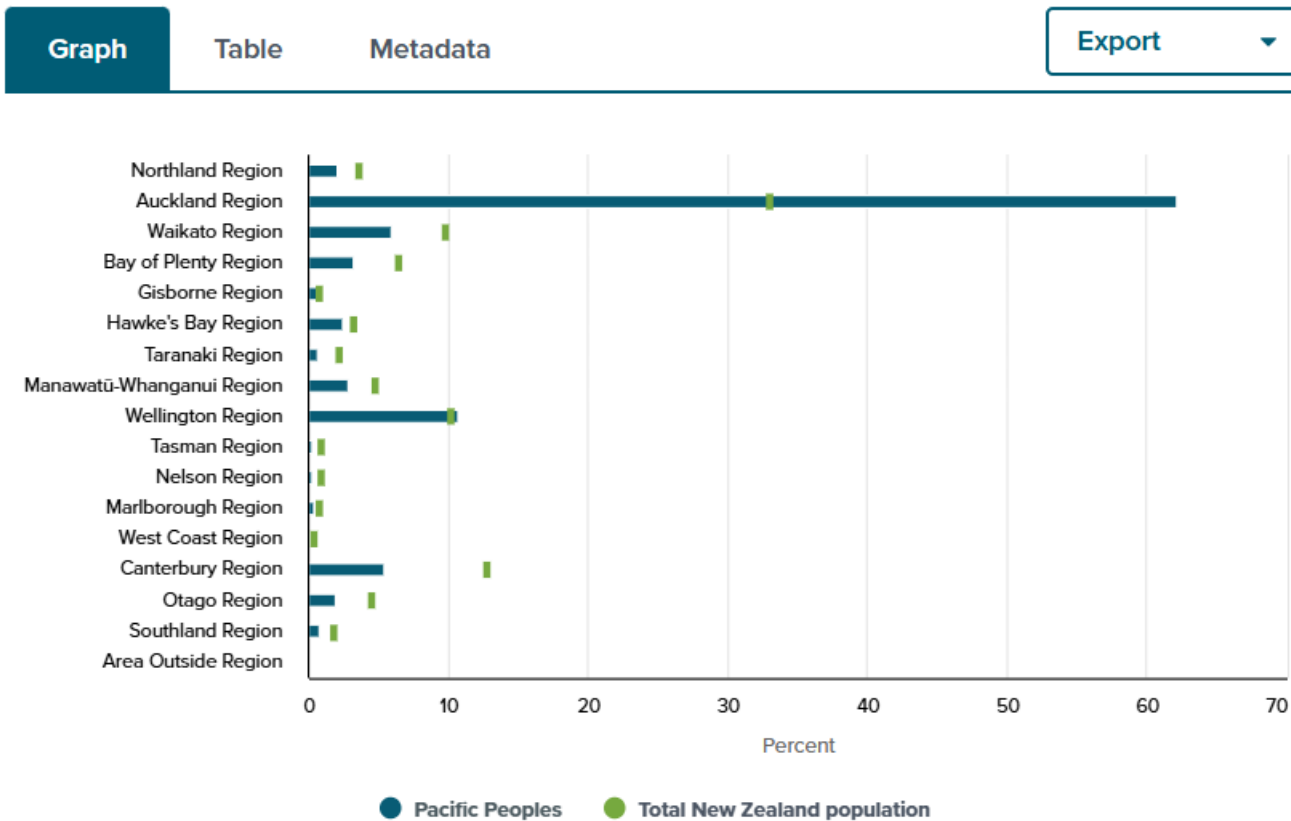
2023 census showed that Pasifika peoples made up 9% of New Zealand's population with approximately 442,632 identifying their ethnic group as Pacific peoples. This increased from the last census in 2018 where 8% (381,642) of the population were identified as Pacific peoples.

Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

ETHNIC GROUP (TOTAL RESPONSE)	NUMBER OF PEOPLE
Pacific Peoples (not further defined)	2,271
Samoan	213,069
Cook Islands Māori	94,176
Tongan	97,824
Niuean	34,944
Tokelauan	9,822
Fijian	25,038
Indigenous Australian	1,161
Hawaiian	699
Kiribati	4,659
Nauruan	120
Papua New Guinean	1,290
Pitcairn Islander	264
Rotuman	1,323
Tahitian	2,019
Solomon Islander	924
Tuvaluan	6,585
Ni Vanuatu	1,161
Pacific Peoples (not elsewhere classified)	564

Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

Percentage of population by regional council area of usual residence, Pacific Peoples and Total New Zealand population ethnic groups, 2023 Census



Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

Percentage of population by age, by total personal income (\$), Pacific Peoples and Total New Zealand population ethnic groups, 2023 Census

Graph

Table

Metadata

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Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

- According to the 2023 Census, the median personal income of Pasifika adults was \$35,200, compared to the median of the total New Zealand population of \$41,500
- The average individual net worth of a Pasifika person over 55 years old is approximately 65 percent less than that of [the average individual of] European ethnicity.
- Only 19.9% Pasifika adults own their home (or hold in a family trust) versus 54% of the total New Zealand population. This is the lowest among recorded ethnicities

<https://tools.summaries.stats.govt.nz/ethnic-group/pacific-peoples>

Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

- A 2022 report from the Pacific Pay Gap inquiry showed that on average Pasifika males were paid 19% less than Pākehā males, while Pasifika women were paid 25% less than their Pākehā counterparts. The report also discussed employers' prejudice against Pasifika names and an undervaluing of Pasifika peoples' qualifications
- Health and poverty statistics published in 2024 showed that 54% of Pasifika children live in homes with food insecurity (in comparison to 27% of the total NZ population); 65% of Pasifika adults were classified as obese; 12.7% of adults reported living with mental health issues; 22.3% of Pasifika adults reported having a medical problem (within the past 12 months) for which did they did not visit health services because of costs.
- Nearly a fifth of Pasifika children in Aotearoa have lived in poverty in the last year (Stats, NZ)

Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

Some results from the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) in 2022:

- Pacific learners performed at a wide range of proficiency levels in mathematics, reading and science. **However, the proportion of Pasifika ākonga performing below the baseline level of proficiency has increased over time.**
- The 2022 average mathematics, **reading and science scores for Pacific learners has decreased since PISA 2018.**
- Pacific students are less likely as their non-Pacific peers to fulfil the requirements to enter university

<https://www.educationcounts.govt.nz/publications/series/2543/pisa-2022/pisa-2022-pacific-learner-summary>

Pasifika in Aotearoa New Zealand

- According to the New Zealand Qualifications Authority's (NZQA) 2024 Annual Report:
 - 71.5 per cent of Year 11 students enrolled in full NCEA Level 1 programmes achieved their qualification in 2024, down from 81.9 per cent in 2023. But for Pacific students, the pass rate was 54.6 per cent, the lowest of any ethnic group.
 - Pacific student achievement rose slightly at Level 3 to 64.6 from 60.4 per cent in the previous year. However, University Entrance (UE) attainment for Pacific learners remained at 32.2 per cent, well below the national average of 50.6 per cent.

Pacific Futures (Salesa, 2017)

“These days, the chief ports of entry for Pacific peoples are the country’s maternity wards. Nowhere is this quite so evident as in Auckland, where one of every four babies born is of Pacific descent; one out of four is Asian; and around one in five is Māori....

....This is one of many critical contributions Pacific people are making to the future shape of New Zealand. In a country that is otherwise aging – the median Pākehā population age is 38 – one of the young and bright spots is the youthfulness of Māori (median age 23.9) and particularly of Pacific people (median age 22.1). However it might play out, the future will increasingly rest in the hands of Pacific, Māori and Asian peoples, and they will lift an even greater share of growing and sustaining New Zealand’s economy, society and way of life.”

Culture

Tillman (2002) defines culture as “a group’s ways of thinking, believing, and knowing, which includes their shared experiences, consciousness, skills, values, forms of expression, social institutions, and behaviors” (p. 4).

- Culture **influences our identity**, informs our behaviour towards, and connections with, others of the same (or different) beliefs.
- Culture **cannot be confined to ethnic culture alone**. It can be used to explain, identify, or define a social class, professional or academic group or any other group which has its own values, beliefs, principles and practices.
- Culture **is always changing, some aspects change quicker than others**. These changes often depend on the environment in which the culture exists.

Values

The things that we:

- Think are important
- Prioritize and aim to uphold



Core Pacific values

- Pacific people come from a diverse range of countries with different languages, have different experiences and include migrants to New Zealand along with second and third generation Pacific people.
- However despite this diversity, Pacific people share a set of common values (Pasifika Education Plan, 2013; 2017)



Core Pacific Values

- Reciprocity, Respect , Service, Relationships, Spirituality, Love, Belonging, Family
- Collectivist values (for the most part): prioritizing the group over the individual.



Va

- Loosely translates to “relationship”.
- The concept stems from the fact that Pasifika cultures are communal...resources are shared and nurturing relationships is important as a matter of sustaining cultural identity
- The foremost goal of *tauhi va* (nurturing and sustaining relationships) is not to accumulate individual gains but rather to sustain reciprocal connections among people.

Va

- Tauhi va is a reciprocal activity whereby the persons involved will give each other time, food, and other material things as a sign of their respect of the va.
- While interpersonal relationships between one person and another can be the focus of the tauhi vā, membership in groups and institutions within the society also creates va and requires one to engage in tauhi va.
 - Relationships within the extended family
 - Relationships within church
 - Relationships within the village
 - Relationships within the country/island



Spirituality

- A narrow interpretation: 'spirituality' could be interpreted as referring to Pacific peoples' high rate of affiliation with Christianity and the role of churches
- 'Spirituality' for Pasifika peoples is much more than Christianity. It is about deep spiritual connections with the natural world going back to ancient times...ongoing relationships with ancestors and sacred sites that exist in spiritual form to guide future generations.
- Spirituality involves...seeking meaning beyond what we can see and touch...Human beings are both physical and non-physical beings.



Spirituality

- Spirituality for Pacific peoples goes back to the earliest of times when Pacific peoples sought to make sense of the world around them...
- Whether living on large volcanic Islands or the smallest of atolls, each Indigenous group learned to carve a living that required them to understand and protect their unique ecosystems. This close relationship was necessary for their survival and for the survival of future generations.
- Deep ancestral ties link current people to those who had connections to the land and who have departed to the spirit world...is reflected in how Pacific peoples view **themselves as 'belonging' to the land, not the land belonging to them.**



Spirituality

Respect for the land and the natural environment is evident in the representation of spirituality in Pasifika art forms...ancient narratives, storytelling, song and dance, drawings, carvings, weaving and traditional Pacific tattoos that depict:

- the existence of higher powers for the creation of all things
- spirits are imbued in all things, from celestial bodies, highest mountains, forests, rivers, and lakes, flora, and fauna, down to the mangroves, coastal landscapes and out to sea.
- and the existence of a spirit world

Pasifika education – aspirations and challenges

Obtaining better educational opportunities for their children is often a key motivation for Pasifika migrants. This is sometimes referred to as the “migrant dream”.



Deficit theorizing

The idea that those who are different from the majority are at a “deficit” (have inherent deficits) and therefore need to be “normalized”...

“deficit thinking perpetuates a blame-the-victim orientation toward communities that face inequalities in society” (Davis & Museo, 2019)

Deficit theorizing...Priority learners

- Although it is laudable that the Ministry of Education has committed to strengthening Pasifika student outcomes through targeted policy and strategic initiatives, **the implications of grouping Pasifika learners as ‘priority’ learners politically places Pasifika into the problematic terrain of deficit theorising** (Matapo & Baice, 2020).
- Research across all education sectors has demonstrated that the notion of **‘priority’ (as lack) has been internalised by many Pasifika students** themselves and has also been taken up in the assumptions of teachers, who, as a result of the label, consider Pasifika students as underachievers (Devine, 2006; Leaupepe, Matapo, & Ravlich, 2017; Matapo, 2018).

Facades (e.g., “diversity”, “inclusion”...)

- In most cases “diversity” is **conceptualized as being about those who look “different”**—that is, not-white—which results in the deflection of attention from the ethnocentrism and hegemony of those who look “the same”, that is, white/Palagi.”
- When people talk about diversity, they tend to refer to “the others” (those who traditionally don’t belong), which in turn immediately establishes those who are not “the others” as “the norm” (“those who belong”)...**Diverse bodies become mere add-ons to the base**

Neoliberalism

- Neoliberalism, or neoliberal capitalism, is the dominant economic and political ideology in Aotearoa New Zealand (and globally).
- Neoliberalism reflects the tenets of classical liberalism (the self-interested individual and free market, laissez-faire economics) but is characterized by intense individualism, consumer sovereignty, freedom and choice, competition, marketization, and modes of governmental and institutional regulation that rely on performativity and audit mechanisms (Olssen & Peters, 2005).



Changes that the democracy of Aotearoa New Zealand has undergone ...

Moving
from:

- a social welfare model of socio-economics

Towards:

- market-based model (neoliberalism) – government and social institutions of Aotearoa NZ as part of global competition

Neoliberalism

Transition toward a market-based model with global aspects affects education:

- A lot of changes in education during the period 1980 to 2000 – Tomorrow's Schools, the education act of 1989, abolishment of corporal punishment, implementation of a national curriculum and other changes.
- The **underlying philosophy of these changes** was the belief that implementing self-management of schools would improve administration and educational outcomes, **creating a 'free market of education'** dependent on results and accountability (Sullivan, 1993, p. 156).
- The belief was that **creating competition** between schools would **improve the quality of education** because schools that were not achieving the results expected by parents would lose pupils and therefore funding, while the opposite would be the case for schools that were achieving the desired high results (Connew, 2003, p. 49)



Neoliberalism

- Education focuses on producing “good neoliberal individuals” (of course, this does not mean that education does not produce any type of people)
- The problem (for Pasifika) is.... neoliberalism is deeply at odds with Pacific core values...worldviews, which negatively impacts Pasifika peoples in profound ways...
 - NB: the same is true for Māori (Smith, 2005)



Neoliberalism

- Neoliberal capitalism pervades education in extremely profound ways, converting everything in its path into marketable products and marketable individuals
- Neoliberal capitalist ideology frames the context of life within which Pasifika people live in Aotearoa New Zealand. It produces and reproduces the dire socioeconomic circumstances that an overwhelming majority of Pasifika people find themselves in...and thus needs to be addressed



Thank you for your time 😊
Contact me if you have any questions.

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